interesting piece I have turned was a full chess set and board, based on a 125mm-high king and 50mm-wide chessboard squares.As with most of my work, it was a commission. I experimented with different wood before settling on rosewood (*Dalbergia latifolia*) and box (*Cornus florida*) and particularly enjoyed the challenge of carving four knights on top of their turned bases, not having done much carving before. Making 16 identical pawns, four rooks and bishops, and two kings and queens required some thinking about design and technique. I settled on using a beading tool to create two measured beads on each piece, one at the bottom and one near the top. All that was needed then was to shape the space between them and turn the top.

Large oak (*Quercus robur*) burr bowl – pitted and cracked, but full of character

English trophy – a memorial trophy made to commemorate a former Head of English at Malton School

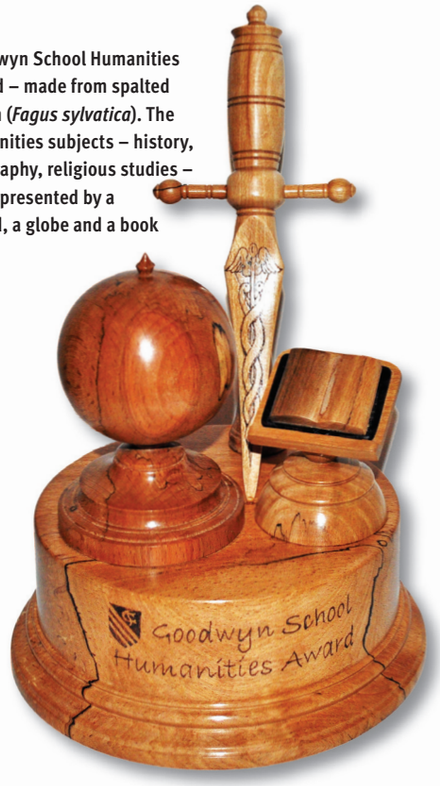
Name one thing on your turning 'to do' list...

As a maths teacher I came across a mathematical solid known as a Klein bottle. This is a solid 'bottle', but it only has one side; its inside is also its outside and it has no boundaries. I am sure I can turn one, probably involving segmented turning techniques… one day.

Tell us about the piece you are currently working on...

I usually work on a handful of pieces at a time. One currently on the go is a 610mm diameter sycamore (*Acer pseudoplatanus*) memorial plaque. The disc is turned, it now needs pyrographing with the names of those students and staff from where I used to teach – Malton School – who gave their lives in both World Wars.

Cricket trophy – ash (*Fraxinus excelsior*) base and wickets, with a ball made from padauk for its reddish colour. Army badge pyrographed and painted. Made for the Army Training Centre in Pirbright, Surrey



Goodwyn School Humanities Award – made from spalted beech (*Fagus sylvatica*). The humanities subjects – history, geography, religious studies – are represented by a sword, a globe and a book

What is the one piece of equipment or tool you would not be without and why?

Apart from the obvious lathe, gouges and chisels, I would not be without my Peter Child pyrography kit. When I first started turning trophies, getting lettering on them involved either fixing metal plates, or using computer-generated vinyl transfer lettering. Both of these required work by another person, so the piece was not entirely my creation. Nowadays I transfer computer generated mirror-image designs from an ordinary inkjet printout rubbed on to the wood, then pyrograph over this outline.

If you could change one thing what would it be and why?

I am not sure about changing one thing. I like to think that things happen as they happen, and they are as they are. It doesn't pay to be thinking what might have been, if only something else had happened.

What is your favourite type of turning?

I am happy doing all types of turning, whatever is required by a particular request. Left to my own devices with no requirement to sell a piece or fulfil a commission I would probably mainly turn bowls – I love the endless variety of such a basic shape and the subtle effects that very minor changes in shape can have.

If you had one wish, what would it be?

Wishes are for magical things, aren't they? I wish woodturning and sanding didn't produce dust.

If you could have one piece of equipment, what would it be and why?

I think I might like a vacuum chuck, but never having used one I don't know if one would be a good investment. Finding ways of holding pieces while turning is all part of the fun, but a vacuum chuck might allow designs that would otherwise not be possible ●

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